

a maximum, the United States has changed greatly since the Declaration of Independence was signed. Modern America is a country with national, state and local governments that are infinitely more powerful than was ever envisioned by our founding fathers. Today, the hand of government can be felt—regulating, prescribing, proscribing and standardizing—in almost every area of human activity.

True, our nation's citizens are as free as any people on the face of the earth, far more than most. But just **how**

free are they? To what extent has government already encroached on their freedoms and their rights to life, liberty and the pursuit of happiness?

I think the average American would be astounded to realize how many commonplace things he may **not** do unless he maintains standards set by government and obtains permission from government to do them in the first place. I rather doubt that most people have ever stopped to think about it.

For example, the average American citizen cannot sell a bottle of beer, get married, go hunting or fishing, drive an automobile or even keep a dog for a pet without appropriate licenses from government. In most places throughout the United States, he cannot hold a parade, build a house or even add a bathroom to his home unless he first obtains permits to do these things from government. He must not operate so much as a pet shop, a boardinghouse or a soda fountain without licenses or permits from such government departments as police, health, fire and so on, ad bureaucratic infinitum.

From the moment he is born and his birth certificate is filled out and recorded, the average American is a marked human being. His life, habits and activities become the

184

concern of numberless bureaucratic offices and agencies which register, enroll, scrutinize, supervise and regulate him and whatever he may do until the day he dies, and even after.